Still Life

By Emily Mann

MARK: My biggest question to myself all my life was: How I would act under combat? That would be who I was as a man. I read my Hemingway. You know . . . The point is, you don't ***need*** to go through it. I would break both my son's legs before I let him go through it. I've thought about it. A lot.

The truth of it is, it's different from what we've heard about war before. I don't want this to come off as a combat story. It's a tragedy is what it is. It happened to a lot of people. And you don't ***need*** to go through that shit. It's ***bullshit***. It just chews people up. I did things over there. We all did *(quietly to audience.)* We all did.

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INTRODUCTION

New research shows that four decades after the Vietnam War ended, more than 270,000 veterans who served in the war zone suffer from symptoms of PTSD, a mental health condition characterized by painful flashbacks, severe anxiety, and uncontrollable thoughts about the disturbing events they experienced. Nothing about war, particularly the Vietnam War, can be experienced 2nd hand by people who were not present.

And defining "war crimes" in Vietnam is not a simple black and white issue . . . No more than war crimes in Iraq, Afghanistan or Syria today. You see, there simply are no rules that apply to a nine-year-old boy as an enemy combatant. Is Mark in Emily Mann's Still Life a war criminal or a war hero? I'll leave that up to you to decide.

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MARK: There was this whole trip that we were really special. And our training was really hard, like this whole Spartan attitude. And there was this whole ethic: you do not leave your man behind on the field. I love that.

I came to a point in there: Okay, you're here, there's no escape, you're going to get taken, it's all right to commit suicide. And it was as rational as that. We came across a hit at night, we got ambushed, it was a black guy walking point, and you know, bang, bang, bang. You walk into it. It was a surprise. Well, they got this black guy. And they took his body and we found him about a week later . . . And they had him tied to a palm tree. They'd opened up his stomach and it had been pulled out. And I knew . . . Nobody was going to do that to me. Better for me to rationalize suicide because I didn't want . . . that. I don't know.

R.J. was my best friend over there. He and I got into a whole weird trip. We found ourselves competing against one another, setting up ambushes, getting people on ***kills*** and things, being the best at it we could. R.J. is dead. He got killed in a bank robbery in Chicago. (He was one of the few friends of mine who survived the war.)

I heard from one guy on a regular basis, maybe once a year. He was green to Viet Nam. We were getting into some real heavy contact. It was late at night, the VC went to us while we were sleeping. They just threw grenades in on us. The explosion came, I threw this kid in a bush. All I did was grab him down, and he got a medical out of there. But he feels I saved his life. He was only in the bush maybe five, six weeks, but it did something to him. He spent two years in a mental institution. I don't know. I knew he knew what I knew . . . .

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It's become a ***personal*** thing. The guilt. It's getting off on having all that power every day. Because it was so nice. I mean, it was power . . . I had the power of life and death. It's like the best dope you've ever had, the best sex you've ever had. You never find anything better. And that's not something you're supposed to feel good about.

I haven't told you what a marine is yet. I mean, we were trained to do one thing. That's the one thing about the marines. We were trained to kill. I had the power of life and death. I dug it. I enjoyed it. I really enjoyed it. It's getting hard to talk. I need to tell this, but I don't want to be seen as . . . a monster.

I look at my face in a mirror, I look at my hands, and I cannot believe . . . I did these things . . . . I'm sorry. I don't think you can understand. It was this duty thing. It was like: **YOU'RE UNDER ORDERS.** You have your orders, you have you job, you've got to ***do*** it. Well, it was like crazy. At night, you could do anything . . . it was free fire zones. It was dark, then all of a sudden, everything would just burn loose. It was beautiful . . . you were given all this power to work outside the law. We all dug it. But I don't make any excuses for it. I may even be trying to do that now. I could have got out. Everybody could've. If EVERYBODY, had said no, it couldn't have happened.

(pulling photos from his bag) I brought some photos. This is a picture of some people who at one point in time were in my unit. That is, they were there at the time the photo was taken. Some of them are dead, some of them made it home. (Pause) Some of them are dead now. This photo is of some guys in my unit. We were South/South-West of Danang--we were in that whole triangle, not too far from where My Lai was. Near the mountains, near the coast. Everybody knew

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about My Lai. But it wasn't different from what was going on. I mean, the grunts did it all the time. This fellow up there, that's Michele. He ended up in the nut-house, that's the fellow I pulled out of the bush. This is the machine gunner. The kid was so good he handled the gun like spraying paint. This kid was from down south. Smart kid. He got hit in the head, with grenade shrapnel. He's alive, but that was the end of the war for him. There were no two ways about it . . . You knew that you were killing something. You actually knew it, you saw it, you had the body. You didn't take wounded. That was it. You just killed them. And they did the same to you.

(Focuses on picture of him with medal. Full Dress) This is a picture of my first purple heart. We were out in the bush. To me, a Purple Heart meant it was something you got when you were wounded and you bled. You were hurt during a contact. I didn't feel anything getting it. But I wanted a picture of it. Actually, I was pissed off about getting that medal. What can I say? I am still alive--my friends aren't. It's a still life.

Here's a picture of me . . . and some kids. *(snaps on picture of him and some children)* God I ***LOVED*** those kids. Everybody hated them. You couldn't trust 'em. The VC would send the kids in with a flag. I never saw this, I heard about it, the kid would come in asking for C-rations, try to be your friend, and they'd be maybe wired with explosives or something and the kid'd blow up. There was a whole lot of weirdness. I really dug kids. I don't know why. *(more pictures of kids)* I did a really bad number . . . it went contrary, I think, to everything I knew, I'm not ready to talk about that yet.

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You know, I get panicky if there's any element of control taken away from me. (I don't like to be alone in the dark. I'm scared of it.) I don't like fireworks. I've had bad dreams when my wife's had to bring me back out. I've heard about vets killing their wives in their sleep. But this is personal – for me, the gun was always the instrument, or a grenade. I never grabbed somebody and slowly killed them. I've never choked them to death of anything. I never killed with my bare hands. *(Pause)*

I need to tell you what I did. *(shows picture of wounded children)* This is a picture of some kids who were hurt. I used to take care of them, change their bandages and all. I loved these kids, Oh, God . . . You want to hear what I did? It's real confusion. I'm guilty and I'm not guilty. I want to tell. I need to tell what I did.

I . . . I killed three children, a mother and a father in cold blood. I killed them with a pistol in front of a lot of people. I demanded something from the parents and then systematically destroyed them. And that's . . . that's what I'm carrying around. For the rest of my life . . . This is what I'm carrying around. A friend hit a booby-trap. And these people knew about it. I knew they knew. I knew that they were working with the VC infra-structure. I demanded that they tell me. They wouldn't say anything. I just wanted them to confess before I killed them. And they wouldn't. So I killed their children and then I killed them. I was angry. I was angry with all the power I had. I couldn't beat them. They beat me. *(crying)*

I have a child . . . a child. My son . . . my son wouldn't know the difference between a VC and a Marine. The children were so little. It's no different than what the Nazis did. It's the same thing. I know that I'm not alone. I know that other people did it, too. More people went through more hell than I did . . . but

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they didn't do this. I guess deep down I'm just everything that's bad. *(long pause)* But, I should have done better. I mean, I really strove to be good. I had a whole set of values. I had 'em and I didn't. I want to censor myself for you. I didn't want you to say: what kind of a nut, what kind of a bad person is he? And yet, I'm not gonna lie. See, I don't want to see people going through another era of being so ignorant of the fact that war kills people. It will happen again. I don't want more children to die. I want to come to the point where I tell myself that I've punished myself enough. In spite of it all, I don't want to punish myself anymore.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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